nature, which had prevailed in Europe since the dawn of global exploration in the late 15th century, began with naturalists such as Gilbert White. Echoed in the sentiments of Romanticism, such ideas tended to focus on the idealization of nature, rather than examining the harm done by human conquests of the natural world.

In contrast to the emotive Romantic responses to modernism, American polymath George Perkins Marsh took a close look at humans' impact on the environment and suggested changes. Marsh was horrified by the destructive effects of human management of natural resources. In his book *Man and Nature, Or, Physical Geography as Modified by Human Action* (1864), he pointed in particular to the mass deforestation which had virtually desertified some areas of the US.

Marsh believed that people must be made aware of their destructive impact and find new ways of managing natural resources to preserve the natural equilibrium. An activist as well as writer, he helped establish the principle of protected areas, and inspired the idea of sustainable resource management that became a core element of the 19th-century environmental movement.